

The Other Side of the Hill

version 2

For Leo, who is braver than he thinks.

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The people and the places

Characters

- **Bruno** — scruffy terrier, Leo's constant companion; loyal, sensible, afraid of deep shadow but braver than he pretends — first appears in chapter 1
- **Leo** — the protagonist, ten years old; curious, observant, brave though he denies his fear — first appears in chapter 1
- **Marcos** — the grandfather; patient, knowing, a builder of cardboard observatories; he walks slowly and speaks in stories — first appears in chapter 1
- **Rosa** — the baker's daughter, same age as Leo; practical, quick-thinking, braver than he is about admitting what frightens her — first appears in chapter 2
- **Elena** — a girl, twelve years old, living with her grandmother on the other side of the hill; quiet, observant, rooted to the land — first appears in chapter 5

Places

- **Mediterranean** — Leo lives in a house at the edge of a small village in a landscape of stone and scrub, where the Mediterranean heat eases in the evening and the cicadas know when to start their song. (*first chapter not recorded*)

The story

Leo is ten years old today and finally old enough to climb the hill behind his house that he has never crossed—but only if he is home before the sun touches the horizon. What he is really afraid of, though he will not admit it, is not the dark itself, but getting lost, and whether he and Bruno, his scruffy terrier, will make it home.

He packs his fossil and his stones. He walks the path through deep shade where Bruno presses against his leg and whines. He names his fear aloud, voice cracking, and goes on anyway. And when the sun touches the horizon at the crest, he finds what no one in the village has ever mentioned: a valley with a stream and fields, a stone house with a wall, and a girl standing in the yard with her hand over her eyes.

One kitchen, one warm meal, one fossil on a shelf that looks almost like his own. By morning Leo is walking home changed. His grandfather, asked straight out, finally answers plainly. And Leo writes in his notebook: Elena has a fossil too. We are the same kind of person. Then he asks whether he can go again.

A warm, funny summer quest about bravery—not the absence of fear, but the choice to move forward despite it—where the greatest wonders are real and a loyal terrier understands more than anyone expects.

Comparables: *Because of Winn-Dixie* by Kate DiCamillo, *The Wind in the Willows* by Kenneth Grahame

Chapter 1 — Ten Years Old

Leo woke before the cicadas stopped singing. The light through his window was already the color of honey, which meant it was late enough that the kitchen would be warm and his grandmother might have left honey on the table with the bread. He lay still for a moment, listening to the particular quiet of ten-year-old mornings — the kind of quiet that felt like it was waiting for something.

Bruno lifted his head from the foot of the bed, saw that Leo was awake, and remembered that he had been sleeping there without permission again. The small terrier scrambled into a tighter ball, but his tail kept moving, betraying him.

"You can stay," Leo said.

The kitchen was exactly as he'd pictured: honey on the table, bread still warm in its cloth, his mother already wearing the look she got on birthday mornings — the one that meant she had been awake for hours. His father was reading the newspaper but reading slowly, the kind of reading that meant he was waiting to look up at something.

"Ten," his father said, not looking away from the page. "Today you are ten."

Marcos arrived while Leo was still eating. His grandfather moved through the door the way he moved through everything, as though he had already walked this path a hundred times and knew exactly where every stone was. He carried a small package wrapped in brown paper, the kind of brown paper that looked like it had been chosen carefully rather than torn from whatever was nearest.

"The stones told me you were ready," Marcos said, which was what Marcos said about most things. He set the package on the table.

Inside was a notebook. Not a school notebook with lines that ruled your thinking into neat rows, but a leather-bound book with blank pages and a spine that creaked when Leo opened it. The leather was soft and darker on the edges where it had been handled, as though the book had been someone else's for a long time before becoming his.

"For seeing," Marcos said. He tapped his walking stick twice against the stone floor. "Not writing down the answers. Writing down the questions you couldn't ask anyone else."

Leo turned the first page slowly. It was empty and it felt important, like standing at the edge of something.

"There's a pencil," his mother said. "In the kitchen drawer. The sharp one we keep."

Bruno followed him to his room. The dog always followed him to his room, but today it felt intentional, as though Bruno understood that something had shifted in the house. Leo opened the window wider to let more light in, then climbed onto his chair to reach the shelf above his desk.

Captain Crunch sat where he always sat, fossil-hard and ancient and worn smooth by whatever water or time had touched it before Leo found it two summers ago on the beach at Cadaques. His father had laughed when he named it after the cereal with the cartoon pirate on the box, and then everyone had laughed, and then nobody had called it anything else. It was not a formal name, but it was the real one.

He placed the new notebook carefully beside the fossil, close enough that they looked as though they belonged together. The afternoon light coming through the window was different from the light he usually saw at this hour, or maybe the leather of the notebook was catching it and throwing it back in a way that made everything look sharper. He picked up Captain Crunch — the familiar weight of it, the smooth curve that felt like it had been made to fit his palm — and looked at it in this new brightness.

The light showed him something he hadn't quite seen before: a thin ridge that ran along one side, like the edge of a shell, like something that had once been alive and had folded itself into this shape. He turned it slowly. Maybe it had been a creature that curled up when it was afraid. He set it down gently and opened the notebook.

With the sharp pencil, he wrote the first question: "What shape was it?"

He did not write the answer. Marcos had been clear about that.

Bruno had found the cool corner of the room where the stone wall stayed cold even when the rest of the house burned with summer heat. He circled three times and collapsed onto the rough tile, his chin resting on his paws, watching Leo with the patient expression of a dog who knew there would be supper eventually.

At the kitchen table at six o'clock exactly, when the light had turned golden and starting to lean toward evening, his mother set the bread down and his father folded his newspaper. Leo's mother had made the soup that meant something was being celebrated, the one with tomatoes and basil and small pasta shapes, the one that took all morning.

"Your mother wants to know if you're planning to do something dangerous with your birthday," his father said.

"I'm ten," Leo said. "I'm not afraid of anything."

His father waited, the way adults do when they know you haven't finished speaking.

"I want to go to the hill," Leo said.

The spoon stopped in his mother's hand. Not for long — she was watching him carefully but not as though he'd said something impossible. Marcos, who had appeared at the table as he always did at supper time, looked at his own bowl.

"You're old enough," his father said. He cut his bread in half. "You'll go in the daylight. You'll be home before the sun touches the horizon. That is the only rule about the hill."

"The sun touches—" Leo started.

"When it is fully down," his father said, "the paths change. Distance becomes unreliable. You don't go learning a place in the dark." He put the bread in his mouth and chewed. His father was not a person who gave long speeches. When he spoke, it meant something. "When you are older and you've crossed it a hundred times in daylight, then you can think about learning it in the dark. For now: daylight. Home before the sun touches the horizon."

Bruno ate steadily from his own bowl under the table, an arrangement nobody had officially agreed to but everyone had understood for years. His tail thumped the floor in the rhythm of a dog who knew that supper meant eventually Leo would also be under the table, dropping pieces of bread.

Leo didn't answer. The rule was clear. The rule wasn't unreasonable — it was just that suddenly the hill was real in a way it hadn't been before, and real things that are allowed are somehow much more frightening than things that are forbidden.

He reached into his pocket where, without deciding to, he had put one of the stones from his collection that morning. It was a small smooth stone from the river, gray with a white stripe running through it, the kind that fit perfectly in the hollow of his palm. He turned it over and over while he ate, feeling its warmth under the kitchen light, while his father folded his newspaper again, and his mother watched him with the look that said she knew this day had meant something, and the stone turned, and turned, in his hands.

Chapter 2 — What's Beyond

Leo sat on the edge of his bed with his stone jar open beside him and a canvas bag on his lap. The morning was already hot. Cicadas were sawing away in the olive trees beyond the garden, and through his window he could see the dry grass shimmering where his mother had stopped watering it three weeks ago.

He looked down at the forty-three stones.

The grey one with the white stripe he picked up first, turning it over in his palms the way he had been doing since yesterday at supper. There was no question about this one—it was his best thinking stone, worn smooth by a river that was probably miles away by now. That had to come. He set it gently in the bag.

The yellow one from the beach at Cadaques was next. Small, almost perfectly round. He had found it the same summer as Captain Crunch, which seemed important, though he could not have said why. He added it to the bag.

Three more smooth stones—one black, one speckled, one the color of old cream—went in after that. He was not sure what he needed them for exactly. Some things, he was learning, did not need a reason before you packed them. They just seemed to belong.

The fossil he lifted last, turning it in the light from his window. The thin ridge along one side caught the sun just right, and for a moment it really did look like the edge of a shell. Captain Crunch had been somewhere. It had been in the ground for longer than anyone could count, or lived in the sea, or both. If anything in this bag was going to be lucky, it would be that.

He wrapped the fossil in his spare handkerchief and set it in the center of the bag, where it would not knock against anything else. Then he took the new leather-bound notebook from the shelf—the one with the question about the fossil's shape already written inside in his own careful printing—and slid it down beside the stones.

When he lifted the bag to feel its weight, it seemed perfectly right. Not too light. Not too heavy.

Bruno was waiting by the kitchen door, leash in mouth.

Leo stopped. He had left the leash coiled on the hook above the coat stand. He had not told Bruno anything about going anywhere.

His mother was at the kitchen table with her coffee, and she looked up with a smile that said nothing—the kind of smile that meant she knew exactly what was happening and was choosing not to make a big thing of it.

Bruno dropped the leash at Leo's feet and circled three times before lying down exactly where it had fallen. His tail was up. His eyes followed Leo's face.

"Well," Leo said. "All right then."

He picked up the leash and clipped it to Bruno's collar. The dog did not whine. He did not press himself against Leo's leg the way he sometimes did in thunderstorms. He simply stood and waited, his whole shabby terrier body saying yes.

Leo picked up his canvas bag with one hand and held the leash with the other. He was not sure what he had expected to feel before this moment, but he was surprised by how ordinary his own feet looked on the kitchen tiles. The same feet that had walked to school every day since he was five. His mother took a slow sip of her coffee.

"Home before the sun touches the horizon," she said, which was not a question.

"I know," Leo said.

"Not when it is starting to. When it touches."

"I know, Mamma."

She nodded and smiled that same small smile. "Then go."

The village fountain was in the center of the plaza, under a dusty linden tree that had been old when Leo's grandmother was young. He sat on the stone rim and let Bruno lap at the water while he waited for his eyes to adjust after the bright white heat of the walk.

Someone tapped his shoulder.

Rosa was standing over him with flour on both her sleeves, even though it was hours past the morning baking. Her dark hair was stuck to the back of her neck, and she was grinning the way she did when she was about to say something she had been thinking about for a while.

"Where are you going?" she said.

"The hill," Leo said.

"With those stones?"

He felt his face go hot. "Maybe I need them."

"You don't need them," Rosa said, sitting down beside him without being asked. "But you're bringing them anyway, which means you think they're important, which means—" She stopped and brushed flour off her left sleeve, not looking at it. "Which means this is something. What's really on the other side? I've asked my father like five times and he just says 'less interesting than you think' every time, which is such an obviously wrong answer that I know something is there."

Bruno lifted his head from the water and looked at Rosa, his whole face going happy. She leaned over and ruffled his ears.

"Did you ask Marcos?" Leo said.

"I haven't seen Marcos. Did you?"

"No. I thought—" Leo turned a stone over in his pocket, one he had taken from the jar at the last second. "I thought maybe he would tell me if I asked him."

"And would he?"

Leo shrugged. "Maybe in a story. He does that. He circles around the answer until you stop listening and then you know what it was."

Rosa laughed, a quick bright sound. "That's the worst way to tell someone something. It's brilliant." She brushed flour off her other sleeve, still without noticing she was doing it. "It's why you need me. You're good at thinking about things, and listening to old people talk around answers, but I'm good at asking questions that make people stop being mysterious. And also—" She looked directly at him. "Also you shouldn't go alone. What if something happens?"

"Like what?" Leo said, but he already knew the answer, which was nothing and everything, all at once.

"Like you fall. Like you get lost coming back. Like you need someone to laugh if you do something stupid." She stood up and brushed her apron, which did have flour on it, and this time she actually saw it and was surprised. "Also I want to go. I want to see what's there."

She crossed her arms and waited.

Leo looked at Bruno, who was looking at Rosa with his head tilted, waiting too.

"Then I'm coming too," Rosa said.

Chapter 3 — The Hill Will Teach

Marcos was re-taping a seam when Leo found him in the garden.

The cardboard observatory had stood for two summers near the back wall of the house, midnight blue fading to the color of old jeans where the afternoon shadow deepened. One corner of the seam had come loose where the rain had softened the cardboard, and Marcos was patient with it, running his palm across the joint, peeling back the tape slowly so as not to tear anything underneath. His walking stick leaned against the observatory wall within arm's reach. From inside, if you bent close, you could smell the dust that had collected there — a smell like pencil shavings and old boxes and secrets kept in the dark.

Leo had meant to ask last night, or this morning at breakfast, but the question had stuck in his throat each time. Now it came out rushed, while Marcos's hands were busy.

"What is on the other side of the hill?"

Marcos did not turn around. He smoothed the tape and reached for another strip from the roll in his lap, letting the question sit for a moment in the morning air while cicadas sang in the olive trees. The garden smelled of dust and wild rosemary and the particular warmth of stone that had been baking in the sun for hours already. A breeze moved through the olive leaves, and the cardboard observatory creaked very slightly, the sound of it like the settling of an old house.

"Why doesn't anyone talk about it?" Leo added, because the first answer hadn't come and he thought another question might hurry it along.

Bruno, who had followed Leo out from the house, had settled into the dust near the observatory's base and was watching something with great attention — a beetle, perhaps, or the shadow of a leaf shifting in the breeze. He circled three times before lying down, the way he did everywhere, as if he had to wind himself up before he could rest. His nose twitched at whatever story the dust held. Every now and then his tail gave a single happy thump.

"Come here," Marcos said.

Leo came. He watched his grandfather's hands move along the seam, sure and steady, the way they had moved when they built this thing together two summers ago, laughing at the ridiculous crooked tube they'd made at first, the one that pointed at nothing in the sky. Inside the observatory, if you bent to look through the cardboard tube, you could see stars pencilled in on the curved inner walls: Polaris, Orion, Cassiopeia, the names written in careful letters. Leo had written them there when he was eight, before he understood constellations properly, and he had been wrong about some of them, and Marcos had never said so.

"Hand me that glass, would you?"

Leo handed him the lens — the polished circle of glass that served as the telescope's eye. Marcos wiped it with the hem of his shirt, leaving a thumbprint smear, then wiped that away too. He moved through the world the way an old house moves through a storm — steadily, and certain it would still be standing when the wind stopped.

When he finally set the lens down and turned to look at Leo directly, his hand had already moved to the walking stick. He drew it toward him and rested it across his lap. There was a long pause — the kind Marcos made without apology, as if silence were a room he was walking through and there was no hurry to reach the other side.

Then he tapped the stick twice against the ground.

"When your father was ten," he said, "I took him to the far side of the town, to a place where there was a stone wall we wanted to see. He wanted to know how long it would take to get there, and whether we would see it clearly when we arrived, and what we would do when we got there." Marcos paused, tapping the stick once more against his palm, thoughtfully. "I told him the wall would teach him what he needed to know."

He stopped.

Leo waited for the rest of the story, but there didn't seem to be one. There was no rest, no payoff, no proper ending. Marcos had tapped twice — that meant he was telling the truth. But it was the kind of truth that left a person standing with an empty cup, more thirsty than before.

"That's not an answer," Leo said, and even he could hear that his voice had gone a bit sharp, the way it did when he was frustrated with someone he loved. "That's not — you're doing the thing. The story thing."

Marcos's face creased at the corners, the way it did when he was trying not to smile.

"Yes," Marcos said.

"It's not fair."

"No. It isn't."

And that, somehow, was worse than if Marcos had defended himself or explained or tried to make it better. Bruno lifted his head from the dust, sensing the edge in the air the way dogs do, and trotted over to press his small warm weight against Leo's leg. Leo's hand went down automatically to the scruffy fur, and after a moment he felt the tension begin to drain out of him — not because the question had been answered, but because Marcos was waiting, and Bruno was there, and the morning was still warm and wide and full of hours.

"Your father walked to that wall," Marcos said finally, his voice slower now, more careful. "And he climbed over it, and he found that on the far side there was nothing but another wall, and

beyond that another field just like the one before. He came home disappointed. He thought he had wasted the day."

Marcos was quiet again, gathering the tape roll, smoothing the resealed seam with the heel of his hand, checking it twice.

"But he never asked me again to tell him what he would find before he walked somewhere new. That lesson was already his."

Leo felt Bruno lean harder against his leg. Through the dust he could see the beetle the dog had been watching — a small green thing that had made its way to the observatory's shadow and seemed perfectly content to stay there in the cool, asking nothing of anyone, wanting nothing but the shade and whatever small life beetles want.

"So the hill will teach me," Leo said. It wasn't a question.

"The hill will teach you," Marcos agreed.

He understood: this was all Marcos would say, and the answer was his own to find.

He looked at his hands, which were empty. The day stretched ahead of him, long and bright and full of hours before the sun would touch the horizon.

Chapter 4 — The Lower Path

The afternoon was already warm and the light falling sideways through the olive trees when Leo slipped out of the house with Bruno at his heels. The canvas bag was slung across his shoulder—his six stones, Captain Crunch wrapped in the handkerchief, and the leather notebook Marcos had given him, waiting to be filled with answers. Or questions. He was still not quite sure which one he was supposed to be collecting.

He had made it as far as the edge of the village plaza when Rosa stepped out from behind the baker's awning, her apron still white with flour, and caught his elbow.

"You're going to the hill," she said. Not a question.

"Reconnaissance," he said, which sounded better than "wandering around and hoping to get scared."

"Well, I can't come tomorrow." The words came out so fast he almost missed them. She brushed flour from her sleeve without looking down, a habit so automatic her hand did it before her brain caught up. "Mother's got the ovens going tomorrow for the feast and someone has to mind the counter and the market rush, and I'm someone, apparently, which is extremely unfair because you know I could climb the hill just as well as you, probably better, actually, I've been thinking about it all night—"

"Rosa."

"—and I can't because of bread." She laughed, but it was the laugh that meant she was disappointed. "Bread is ruining my life. So you have to promise. Absolutely promise. You have to tell me everything you see. Everything. The color of the stones, what the path looks like, if it's steep, if there are birds, if anything is weird or strange or—" She brushed her sleeve again, harder, and a little cloud of flour rose into the light. "Does it smell like anything?"

"I haven't been there yet."

"Well, when you do. You have to tell me absolutely everything." She was looking at him seriously now, underneath the tumble of words. "Promise."

He promised.

"Because I can't ask my father anymore," she said, quieter. "He just keeps saying it's less interesting than I think, and I don't believe him, and he knows I don't believe him, so now we just don't talk about it." She shook her head. "I'll have flour in my hair by tonight and my feet will hurt. But you—you get to actually go."

He wanted to say something to make it better, but Rosa was already brushing past him toward the bakery, her apron leaving a little ghost of flour in the air. Bruno whined and pressed against his leg.

"I know," Leo said. "It's not fair."

The path to the foot of the hill was one he knew well—past the last houses, past the stone wall where the village ended, across a stretch of scrubland where the earth was pale and hard and wanted nothing from anybody. The sun was already beginning its slow tilt toward the west, still high enough that the sky was still blue, but the heat was different now, less fierce, gentler. The light was shifting. He could feel it happening, the world changing from the bright hammer of midday into something more golden, more slanting. Bruno walked close, his ears up, sniffing at the stones and the dry grass as if each one was a message left for his nose alone.

When they reached the base of the hill proper, where the slope began to rise, the ground changed under their feet. The path here was not one that anyone had made on purpose—it was older than that, worn into the hillside by years of feet and hooves and weather, generations of creatures climbing and climbing and leaving their marks in the earth. It was marked with stones, small ones placed as if someone was saying: this way, follow this. Leo could see it clearly, the route stitched up the slope in pale markers against the darker earth, deliberate as a thread sewn by patient hands.

He started to climb.

The first stretch was easy enough. The stones were solid under his boots, and the slope was steep but not terrible. Bruno climbed easily at his side, his paws sure on the path, his tongue lolling slightly with the pleasure of work. The air changed as they went higher—cooler, touched with the smell of wild thyme that grew between the stones, bruised green and sharp and bright. It smelled like the hill wanted you to know it was alive, wanted you to know it was there. His legs felt strong, and his breathing was steady, and Bruno's ears stayed up and happy, twitching at every sound.

They passed the first stands of pine trees, where the needles had made the earth soft and dark and rich. The shade was welcome after the exposed slope. He could see the path continuing up and up, marked by those patient stones, and his heart was beating faster—not from fear, he told himself, but from the climb, from the work of it. Longer shadows stretching across the stones like dark fingers.

Higher still, the path began to turn—up and around the curve of the hill toward whatever lay beyond. That was when the ground changed again. The loose stones became more common here, shale and flint that wanted to slide under his boots with every step. The path ahead of him narrowed, and shadow pooled across it in thick places. The pine trees grew thicker, their needles blocking out the sky, and the light took on that peculiar quality of places where the sun couldn't reach directly anymore—dimmer, cooler, uncertain.

He stopped.

The path ahead looked both tempting and wrong—tempting because it continued, clearly marked with stones, inviting him on, and wrong because the afternoon was already turning and he was only supposed to have so much daylight. He was doing the arithmetic in his head, feeling the numbers in his chest: sun touching the horizon around here meant he needed to be back at the house, home, safe, and if he kept going now he might not be. The numbers didn't work. The loose shale underfoot was treacherous, and the pine needles had made this stretch too dim to trust. And anyway, he thought, there was always tomorrow.

Bruno stopped when Leo stopped, ears still up, alert, not worried. The dog didn't want to turn back from anything—his ears had stayed happy all the way up, happy still. He simply waited for Leo to decide.

"Come on," he said to Bruno, and they turned around.

The dog followed without hesitation, without any reluctance, as though they had been planning this return all along. His ears stayed up all the way down, swiveling at the sounds of insects and birds. When they reached the foot of the hill again, the light had begun in earnest to change. The sun was still above the horizon, still visible between the trees and buildings of the village, but it was clearly heading toward the edge of the world. The shadows had grown long and purposeful, pointing like fingers toward home. Toward supper. Toward his mother asking him where he had been.

Tomorrow, he thought. Tomorrow I do this alone.

Chapter 5 — The Climb

The sun was high and the world was blue. Leo and Bruno set out after breakfast while the air was still cool and the whole day lay ahead of them like a promise. The stone path was clear beneath his feet, the leather of his shoes worn smooth by his own walking, and Bruno trotted beside him with his nose down, reading the morning in the dust.

They climbed steadily. The village fell away below them, small and ordinary, rooftops and gardens and the ribbon of the stream. The pine shadows grew longer as they rose, and the air changed—thinner, clearer, the kind of air that made him feel he could see everything. He could see the fountain where Rosa said goodbye. He could see the ovens where she was working instead of being here. He had promised to tell her everything.

His legs began to ache. Not sharply yet, but a steady pulling in his thighs and a burning in his calves that sharpened with each step upward. Bruno felt it too; his trotting slowed, his tongue lolling in the afternoon heat. The sun that had felt cool in the morning was working harder now. Sweat stuck his shirt to his back. The higher they climbed, the smaller the world below became, until the village looked like something painted on paper, unreal and distant. His breath came harder. Each step demanded more thinking than the last—deciding whether to continue, whether his body could keep going. The path that had been clear began to ask questions.

Past the shepherd's markers, the path began to disappear.

The stones were still there, worn by feet and weather, but they came and went now, and between them was loose shale and low brush. He had to watch where he placed each step. Bruno was still beside him, but something in the dog's manner had changed. He stayed closer, his usual trotting urgency gone. When they paused in a stretch of deep shade beneath an overhang of rock, Bruno moved against Leo's leg and whined—a thin, sharp sound that cut through the afternoon stillness.

Leo stopped. His breath was coming shorter than it should, his palms suddenly damp. The stones around him felt loud under his feet, as if they might give way. He turned smooth pebbles over in his hands, the way he did when thinking, and understood something true about himself:

It was not the dark he was afraid of.

"Bruno," he said aloud, and his voice cracked. "I don't know if I can—" He swallowed hard. His hand shook when he reached down to touch the dog's head. "What if I can't find the way back down from here? What if we get lost and I can't find the path and you're trusting me and I can't—I don't know the way."

The dog leaned against his shin. His small body was warm. Leo thought of his mother, of his father, of the table where they would all sit at supper—and of the empty chair that would be his, the plate kept warm. He thought of Bruno's leash, which the dog had fetched himself on Day 2, which meant Bruno knew they were going somewhere that mattered.

He went on.

The climb sharpened. The fear did not leave—it sat in his ribs like something that had made a nest there—but he climbed anyway. One foot, then the other. Bruno stayed pressed against him, his breath quick and anxious, but forward.

And then, without warning, the ground leveled.

His breath rushed back in. The ache in his legs shifted, changed into something lighter. For a moment he stood still, chest heaving, and felt the fear drain out of him like water from cupped hands—not disappearing entirely, but settling into a smaller shape, something he could carry rather than something that was carrying him.

They stepped out into light and space. Before them lay a whole valley that did not exist from the village—had never been mentioned in all the village talk, never been real until this moment. There was a stream, silver in the failing light, and fields that descended to a stone house with a wall around it. There was a stream, silver in the afternoon sun, and fields that went down toward a stone house with a wall around it. The house was small and solid and real. In the yard, someone was standing with one hand over her eyes, looking up at the hill.

Looking at him.

She was a girl, perhaps twelve, with dark hair and a brown dress. She stood motionless, working something out, and then she called across the distance. Her voice reached him thinned and strange, as if traveling miles, though the valley was not wide—or was it? It sounded both nearer and farther than he could tell.

"Who are you?"

He took the first step down the slope toward her.

The sun touched the horizon.

The light changed in an instant. The crest behind him was still bright, but the valley below darkened all at once, and distance became unreliable. Things looked both nearer and farther than they truly were. He felt it in his chest—the rule arriving, the rule his father had given him, arriving with sudden force and weight. It did not say run. It said stop, wherever you are, when the sun touches the world's edge. Wait. Remain. Let daylight return. And that waiting is not a failure or a breaking of obedience. That is how you keep safe. That is the bravest thing.

He had not broken his father's rule. He was keeping it now.

From below, in the yard, Elena's voice reached him—stretched thin and strange by distance, sounding both very close and impossibly far. "You can't come down," she called, uncertainty bright in her voice. "Can you? Not safely now."

She was climbing toward him. He could see her now, moving up the slope with careful steps, taking her time, letting her feet find the way in the changing light. She moved as if she had walked this slope in darkness before, as if the dark was just another thing the land asked of her.

When she reached him, her breath was steady and her eyes serious, considering his face.

"Come on," she said simply. She bent and took Bruno by the collar, her hand gentle and certain. "We have to go to the house now. My grandmother—I'll need to tell her."

Together, the three of them descended toward the stone house with its lit windows, toward warmth and shelter and the smell of food cooking. Elena led them both toward the light.

Chapter 6 — On the Other Side

The kitchen was smaller than Leo's own kitchen at home, and warmer. There was a wooden table that looked as if it had been serving supper in the same room for fifty years, and Elena's grandmother moved around it without fuss, setting down bread and cheese and a pot of soup that steamed as if it had been waiting for someone all along. The stone walls were the same grey as the walls at home, rough and honest, and in the window above the sink someone had left a smooth pebble on the sill—just one, turning slightly in the last of the daylight.

"Sit," Elena's grandmother said, and it was not a question. Her name was Clara, and she had the same quiet voice as her granddaughter, but older, with the kind of patience that comes from a life lived slowly. "The boy will be hungry."

He was. Bruno circled the kitchen floor three times, each circle smaller than the last, before collapsing with a sigh into the corner nearest the table. When Clara set a bowl of broth in front of him, he ate without speaking, and the bread was dark and still warm from the oven. There were no questions asked about where he had come from or why he had arrived at sunset with a scruffy dog and a nervous voice.

Leo kept thinking about his own table, the other side of the hill. His plate was laid. His place was waiting. His mother would be clearing the other dishes now, and his father would be reading in the window, and Marcos would be smoking his pipe in the doorway, and nobody would be worrying yet because he had once said he was not afraid of anything, and everyone believed him a little longer than they should have. But he was here now, and the soup was good, and Elena was across the table from him turning a piece of bread over in her hands as if it held a story written in the crust.

"Did you really climb the hill in the dark?" she asked.

"I stopped at the top," he said. "The sun was going down."

Clara nodded, the way Marcos nodded sometimes, as if that explained things. "That's the rule then. The hill has rules."

"My grandfather gave it to me," Leo said. "With a rule about the sun. My father's rule, really."

"It's a good rule," Elena said. She set the bread down and picked up her soup bowl. "I found something. Do you want to see?"

She got up without waiting for an answer and went to a shelf above the old stove, where there were four books with broken spines and a shelf-worth of ordinary things: a brass key that opened nothing in this house, a bird's skull so small it fit in her palm, and a fossil.

It was smooth and sleeping, pale as a river stone, shaped like a spiral that had closed on itself a thousand years ago.

"I found it in the riverbed," Elena said. "Last spring. After the thaw."

Leo pulled Captain Crunch out of his canvas bag, still wrapped in the handkerchief, and set it next to Elena's fossil on the kitchen table. His face was hot. He was about to have to say the name out loud, to a twelve-year-old girl he had only met an hour ago, and it was the most embarrassing thing that had ever happened to him.

"It's called Captain Crunch," he said. "I named it when I was eight. After a cereal."

Elena picked up her fossil and turned it over in her hands, slow and careful, the way she turned over everything. Then she picked up Captain Crunch and turned that over too, studying it the way a reader studies a page.

"Does it crunch?" she asked.

"That's a good name," she said. And she meant it. She didn't laugh—not in the bad way. She just held both fossils, one in each hand, and looked at them as if she were reading two stories that fit together. "Mine doesn't have a name yet."

"You could name it," he said.

"Maybe," Elena said. "Maybe I'll wait and see what it tells me."

Clara had gone outside to tend the wall. Bruno's head was heavy on Leo's foot, warm and solid. Through the kitchen window, the hill rose up in the blue-grey light, and the last of the sunset was fading fast, and he understood that he had to leave at first light because that was the rule, and because his plate was being kept warm, and because there were people somewhere learning what it meant to wait.

"We should sleep," Elena said, as if she had read the thought. "If you're going down in the morning."

The night was long and gentle. When the sky was still pale—earlier than Leo expected, earlier than the birds had finished their talking—Elena was already at the door, and Bruno was already standing beside her, and they began the walk down the hill together.

The path was safer in daylight. Leo could see every stone, could see where his feet were going. The sun was rising at the foot of the valley, and it caught the stones of the path and the dry-stone wall that ran down the slope, and turned them gold. Bruno moved between them both, his tail high, quick and pleased, a sharp bark when the sun broke fully over the valley rim.

When they reached the bottom, where the hill met the lower path that led back to the village, Elena stopped and turned back toward the hill. She stood there looking up, her hands empty, and

Leo could tell she was not yet ready to leave. The sun was catching the stones and her hair.

Chapter 7 — The Return

The kitchen door was open and both of them were standing in the yard.

Leo could see them from half a field away. His mother had her arms crossed, which she did when she was waiting, and his father was still, the way he went when something had happened that nobody could fix yet. The morning sun was already high—too high. He had meant to be home when it rose.

He could not read their faces until he was closer. Fear was the first thing. Then something else underneath it that might have been anger, or might have been something harder to name. When he was near enough to see their eyes, he stopped walking.

"I kept the rule," he said.

His mother made a sound that was not quite a word. His father did not move.

"The sun touched the horizon and I was on the other side of the hill. I stopped right there and I waited for the morning, and I came home in daylight, like the rule says. I kept it."

His mother crossed the yard in three strides and gripped his arm. She did not say anything. His father stepped forward and put a hand on his shoulder, and Leo could feel it shaking very slightly.

"Start from the beginning," his mother said into the top of his head.

So he did.

"The path is narrower than we thought. Me and Bruno. We went up after breakfast, when the sun was high and we had the whole day ahead of us, and the path kept going down and down, and then I couldn't hear the village sounds anymore, and I said to Bruno that I wasn't sure which way was back, and that was scary because he was trusting me, and I couldn't let him down, so we just—we just kept going forward because stopping didn't help. And then the path got better and wider and we could see there was a house down in the valley, a real stone house that nobody ever talks about, and there was a girl there, Elena, she's twelve, and she was in the yard, and the sun was right on the horizon and I just—I had to stop. Right there. And that's where I—"

"You slept there," his father said. It was not a question.

"Yes. Elena and her grandmother Clara. They had supper and I told them about our hill and Bruno pressed against me the whole time, frightened, and Elena has this fossil—a spiral, pale as a river stone, smooth like something the water had worked on—and she found it in the riverbed, and I had Captain Crunch so I set him next to the fossil and we looked at them together for a

moment, and I left Elena one of my smooth stones—the striped one—to keep. And in the morning we walked back down and the sun was coming up and when we got to the foot of the hill Elena turned back and I came home."

"Your mother didn't sleep," his father said quietly.

"That's what the rule says. Stop when it touches the horizon. I stopped. I waited for the light to come back. I came home in the light."

He felt his father's hand leave his shoulder. He heard the scrape of the kitchen chair as his father pulled it back and sat down hard. His father put his hands flat on the table, and they were still now, and his father was looking at them the way he looked at things he was trying to work out in his head.

"Neither did I," his mother said. There was something in her voice that was not anger. It was worse than anger. It was the sound of someone who had been afraid for a very long time and was only just putting it down.

Leo smelled something then. He turned his head and saw it: his place at the table, set as it always was. There was a plate on top of it, and on top of that plate another plate, turned upside down to keep the warmth in. The cup beside it had gone cold.

He did not know how long it had been sitting there. He did not want to count.

"That was your supper," his mother said. "From last night. We kept it warm."

She said it the way she said things that were simple facts, but it was the most terrible fact he had heard. They had waited through the night. They had made supper at the hour they always did, and set his place as if he would be home, and kept the food warm all through the dark. And every hour the plate sat there, getting older. All through the hours when they could not sleep—when his mother stood at the window looking toward the hill and the invisible path beyond, and his father walked the floor—they said almost nothing to each other because there was nothing left to say. They had sat down to eat at the usual hour and left his plate there like a promise.

His father's hands were still flat on the table. His eyes were still on them. Then slowly, very slowly, he lifted his eyes to Leo's face.

And nodded.

Just once. A small nod, held for a second, and then his father looked back at his hands.

Bruno pressed against Leo's legs, the way he did when he needed to be close to somebody, needing the feeling of someone there beside him. His mother finally loosened her grip. Bruno trotted straight to his food bowl and began to eat so quickly his whole back end waggled with the effort, and then he came back and barked once, sharp and happy, because he had a story to tell

too and it came out all at once in the language of dogs—the whole hill and the scary path and Elena's yard and a house he had never smelled before and the strange kitchen corner where he circled and finally lay down and walking back in the sunrise—all of it at ankle height, told in quick sharp barks and the way he pressed close and circled three times before lying down on Leo's feet.

"Tell us about Elena," she said. "Tell us about the house. Tell us everything, and take your time."

His mother's hand was back in his hair, not moving, just there.

Chapter 8 — Marcos Knew

Marcos walked into the kitchen as Leo was halfway through describing Elena's fossil—the pale spiral from the riverbed, how it turned in the light like a secret the earth had been keeping for a thousand years. His mother was pouring milk into the blue pitcher, the one with a chip on the rim and still the most beautiful thing on the shelf. His father sat at the head of the table with his chin in his hand, which is what he did when he was listening hard, when he wanted to hear every word and the spaces between them. Bruno lay under the table with his chin resting on Leo's foot, one ear tipped toward that voice, because Bruno could hear the things that mattered in it, could tell when Leo was speaking from somewhere deep and true.

Marcos stopped in the doorway.

He stood there in his good coat, the walking stick in his right hand, the one with the brass knob that had belonged to his own father. He didn't move. He simply looked at Leo, and Leo looked back, and for a moment he forgot entirely what he was saying, forgot the words in his mouth like they had scattered across the floor.

"He spent the night on the other side of the hill," his father said.

It was the plainest thing his father could have said, and he said it plainly, because his father never wasted words. But Marcos—something crossed Marcos's face like a door opening to the light. Not surprise. Not shock. It was the look of a person who had been waiting for a knock and finally heard it, and had always known exactly who it would be.

Leo watched it happen. He watched his grandfather's grey eyes stay exactly the same colour and brightness, watched something behind them shift, settle, become still.

"There is a girl there," Leo said. His voice came out smaller than he meant it to. "And her grandmother. Elena—the girl—she's twelve. She showed me—" He stopped. "Marcos, did you know Elena was there?"

Bruno's tail thumped once against the floor, because he knew that tone, that pause, the way Leo's fingers went to the pocket of his trousers where he kept his smooth stones.

Marcos tapped his walking stick twice against the floor.

The sound was very clear in the kitchen. Tap. Tap.

"I have known Elena's house was there since before you were born, and I wanted you to find it yourself," Marcos said. His voice was not what it usually was. It was simple, the way his father's voice was simple.

One sentence. No story. No walking back to tell it sideways.

Leo felt his chest go hot, then tight. He felt his fingers curl around the edge of the table. He'd been frightened on that hill, frightened of being lost, though he hadn't been. He'd stood on it in the failing light, and he hadn't known if he could trust Bruno with the way down, and he had trusted Bruno anyway because there was nobody else to trust. And Marcos knew. Marcos had always known. He'd known when he gave Leo the notebook for questions. He'd known when he tapped his stick and told the story about the wall.

"You knew," he said. Not a question this time.

"Yes."

It was the plainness that made Leo angry—not the knowing itself, but the plainness that said he was old enough now for the truth without dressing, without stories.

Bruno pressed his whole body against Leo's leg under the table, warm and solid, and Leo pressed back. He reached into his pocket and turned one of the smooth stones with his thumb, because sometimes you needed something to hold while everything else was changing.

His mother reached across the table and moved the butter dish an inch. It was about as much as she had ever said about anything, which meant it was quite a lot.

"You might have told me," Leo said. The anger was still there, bright and small and honest.

Marcos didn't move. He didn't sit down. His walking stick stood on the floor between him and the table, and his hand rested quiet on the brass knob.

"If I had told you," he said, and Leo could see it cost him something—could see it in the pause, in the way his grandfather's jaw tightened and then let go—"you would not have gone. And I think you needed to go. I think you needed to find your own reason to be brave, not because I told you to be, but because you had to be."

Leo opened his mouth. He closed it. He thought about the moment on the hill, when he had stood in the last light and told Bruno aloud that he didn't know the way back. He thought about Elena, coming out into the yard with her hand over her eyes, looking up at the hill. He thought about the fossil, and the table with a place laid for him, and falling asleep in a stone house on the other side of a hill that nobody talked about.

He thought about not going.

If Marcos had told him, he wouldn't have gone.

Bruno came out from under the table and walked three complete circles before lying down directly on Leo's foot again. Bruno's quick sharp bark came next—not happy exactly, but not sad either.

Marcos set his walking stick against the wall, the way he always did, and pulled out his chair.

Leo didn't look away from his grandfather. He met his eyes—the grey ones that had been waiting for this moment since before he was born. Neither of them looked away.

Chapter 9 — The Question Answered

The kitchen was the same as always—the long table, the light through the western window turning everything honey-colored, the smell of his mother's bread and olive oil. Leo sat in his regular place, still dusty from the hill, and nobody said anything about the dirt on the chair. His mother had filled his plate without asking what he wanted. His father sat across from him the way he always did. Marcos was in the corner chair, the one that faced both the table and the door, watching the evening come in.

They ate without much talking at first—just the sound of forks, the clink of water glasses, his mother asking his father something about the shutters that needed fixing. Leo was hungrier than he had ever been. Everything tasted like itself: the bread was bread, salt was salt, the cheese was exactly what cheese was supposed to be. He thought about Clara's kitchen, about the meal there that morning—Elena handing him a thick cup of milk, Clara setting down a plate without fuss—and then he thought about sitting in this kitchen instead, and how it was the same shape of kindness but different in its details, in the way his mother folded her napkin and the particular creak of this chair under his weight.

"You'll want to tell Rosa everything," his mother said. Not a question.

"She won't forgive me if I don't," he said.

His father laughed—a real laugh, not a polite one. "She had a point about the feast ovens keeping her here."

Leo nodded and kept eating. The sun was lower now, the light different. He thought about yesterday, about the moment the sun had touched the horizon and he had understood, really understood, that he could not go further down the hill into the dark. It had been frightening—that moment when the rules and the fear had suddenly meant the same thing. But then Clara had opened the door, and Elena had been there, and fear had become something else. A thing that happened and then was over. The dark had come all around him in that house, in that bed that wasn't his bed, and it had not swallowed him. Bruno had slept at the foot of it, breathing steady. And when the light came back, Leo was still himself, unchanged in any way that mattered.

He lifted his glass and drank. The water was cold. His father was talking about the weather, about whether the heat would break before September. His mother was not really listening; she was watching Leo in that way she had that made him feel known. Marcos was silent in his corner, one hand resting on his walking stick, his eyes on Leo. The rhythm of supper. The rhythm that had held his place all night while he was gone.

After they had eaten, after his mother had cleared the plates and brought out the figs they always had at this hour, Leo excused himself. His mother nodded. Nobody asked where he was going.

He climbed the stairs to his room in the half-dark—twilight now, the last real light draining out of the day—and closed the door quietly.

Bruno was already on the bed, waiting. The dog lifted his head when Leo came in, and when the boy lay down and turned toward the wall, Bruno jumped down and circled. Once, twice, three times—that was his way, the habit of settling that Leo had never thought much about until now. But this time, when Bruno circled, there was no tension in it. He was circling because that was what Bruno did, his body loose and easy, the way he always settled in to sleep. When he lay down at the foot of the bed, he sighed—a small dog sigh, almost content—and rested his chin on his paws.

When Bruno lay down at the foot of the bed, Leo could feel the difference right away. His tail was straight, his ears forward, not pinned back. And his whole body—it wasn't coiled and ready anymore, waiting for something to happen. He was just Bruno, settling in to sleep the way he always did when nothing was wrong. The night was the same as any other night for him. So it was the same for Leo too.

The light went on fading. His room became shades of grey and then something softer than that, something between blue and nothing. On the shelf, Captain Crunch caught what little light was left and seemed to glow—though it was only the pale limestone picking up the last glow from the western sky. Leo thought about Elena's fossil on Clara's shelf, the spiral pale as bone, the way they had stood together looking at both of them, at the two things pulled from the earth that neither of them had made and both of them had kept.

He reached for his notebook. The leather one Marcos had given him, that first morning when he turned ten. He had asked a question on the first page and never gone back to it. Now he opened to a fresh page and found the pencil in the spine where he always kept it. The light was almost gone but there was enough, there was enough for this. He pressed the pencil to paper and began to write, the letters small and careful:

Elena has a fossil too. We are the same kind of person.

The pencil moved across the page and the words took their place, one after the other, true and solid on the paper, exactly as he had meant them to be.

Chapter 10 — The Other Side Now

That evening, after supper had cleared and the light was turning long and gold across the garden, Leo found his father in the kitchen, moving slowly the way people do in heat, and asked him the question he had been holding since breakfast.

"Can I climb the hill again? Soon? With the same rule—home before dark?"

His father looked at him for a long moment, and then smiled. "Yes," he said. "The same rule. And you'll follow it?"

"I will," Leo said, and he meant it the way he had on the day he first asked.

He was outside on the back path, heading toward the garden wall, when Rosa found him at the gate. She must have been waiting there, flour still in the creases of her sleeves, her hair coming loose from where she had pinned it that morning.

"There you are," she said, and her words tumbled out all at once. "I've been waiting since my mother let me go—I told her you'd be home by now, you had to be home by now, or she would have sent someone to look. What happened? What did you find? Did you see something? Is it as strange as everyone says, or is it just rocks and nothing? Tell me everything, you promised you would tell me everything."

She laughed at herself, embarrassed, and brushed flour from her sleeves without noticing she was doing it.

So he told her. About the path that got harder to see. About Bruno pressed against his leg, whining. About the thyme that rose in a smell when you trod on it, and the quick grey birds calling from places you couldn't locate. About how steep it was, steeper than it looked from below. About reaching the crest and seeing the valley spread out below like a secret the hill had been keeping. About Elena, who was twelve and had a house there with her grandmother, and a fossil of her own—pale and spiral-shaped—sitting on a shelf like Captain Crunch sat on his. About how the sun touched the horizon and he had to stop, so he stayed, and the dark was not the thing he had been afraid of after all. About waking early and climbing down in the grey light, Elena steady beside him and Bruno between them.

Rosa's eyes grew wider with each thing he said.

"You stayed there all night?" she asked.

"Yes."

"And you came back the next morning?"

"Yes."

"And Elena—is she kind?"

"Yes," he said. "She collects things the earth leaves behind. Like I do."

Rosa nodded slowly, turning this over in her mind the way she turned flour between her fingers. Then she said, "Next time you go, can I come?"

"Yes," he said, and knew his father would say yes too.

He found Marcos in the kitchen, moving slowly, the way the grandfather moved through almost everything. The old man looked at him without speaking for a long moment.

He could see it already—Elena standing in the doorway of the cardboard box, looking up at the painted stars. But it wasn't only his to show her. It was half Marcos's. He took a breath.

"Can I show Elena the observatory?" he asked aloud.

Marcos tapped his stick twice. And then he spoke plainly, in one sentence, the way people speak who have decided that a young person has earned the truth:

"Yes—she will want to see what you have made of the light."

Together, they walked out into the garden as the evening began to change color, Marcos moving slowly with his stick, and Leo keeping pace beside him. The cardboard observatory stood where it always stood, near the back wall, midnight blue and creaking faintly in the warm breeze. Up close, you could see all the places where the boxes had been taped together, where seams showed underneath the paint like old scars. The pencil marks where eight-year-old Leo had drawn the stars were still there—some in the right places, some not quite, some doubling back on themselves because he had not been sure.

Marcos opened the door, and they went inside.

It smelled like it always smelled: dust and pencil shavings and something like the memory of cardboard. The polished glass lens caught the last of the sun and threw it across the small interior, and the cardboard tube that had been meant for a telescope stood waiting, patient and crooked in a way that made it look kind.

Leo climbed onto the low shelf and Marcos handed him Captain Crunch—the fossil he had found two summers ago at Cadaques, shaped like a sleeping thing, smooth from the sea. The boy placed it on the highest shelf where the light would catch it, there where the best of the evening sun fell.

Then he climbed down and brought the jar of stones from where he kept it, and one by one he and Marcos arranged them on the shelf beside the fossil. The amber river stone glowed where it

caught the light. The smooth river stones sorted themselves by color: white and rust and amber. The black stone from the beach caught the sun and held it like a secret.

Marcos stood quiet, looking at what they had made.

Outside the open door, Bruno had circled three times in the dust of the garden path and was now asleep, his chin resting on his paws, the warmth of the day still in his fur. The cicadas had begun their evening song. The sky above the garden was turning that particular blue that comes just before dusk, the blue that holds gold around its edges.

Leo stood beside his grandfather, and together they looked at the light on the fossil and the stones, the way it moved across the shell-shape of Captain Crunch, the way the amber stone held the warmth of the last sun. Somewhere, on the other side of the hill, Elena was probably looking at the same sky.

The stars were beginning to appear, faint and patient, waiting for the last of the light to leave.

Marcos did not speak. Neither did the boy. There was nothing that needed saying.

Outside, the evening deepened, and the garden held them both.